SOPHIA SPRITE

and the

SASQUATCH SECRET

ALSO BY BRIAN YOUNG

The Sophia Sprite Series

Book 1: Sophia Sprite and the Sasquatch Secret

Book 2: Sophia Sprite and the Banshee Bargain (Coming Soon)

SOPHIA SPRITE

and the

SASQUATCH SECRET

BOOK ONE

BRIAN YOUNG

Sophia Sprite and the Sasquatch Secret
Book One of the Sophia Sprite Series

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For anyone who ever felt like they didn't belong, until they found their people.

CHAPTER ONE

The Last Ordinary Day

The cow-shaped creamer was falling.

The creamer tipped off the counter in slow motion, Dad's elbow catching the edge as he reached for the sugar, his eyes still glued to some boring article about Seattle zoning laws. The heavy ceramic thing her mom had bought at that craft fair last summer tumbled through the air, milk sloshing out the spout.

It was going to shatter. No question.

Dad's hand blurred.

Not reached. Not grabbed. *Blurred.* Like someone had hit fast-forward on just that one part of him while the rest of the world stayed normal speed.

The creamer landed in his palm. Perfectly balanced. Not a drop spilled.

Sophia's toast stopped halfway to her mouth.

Dad blinked down at his hand like he'd just noticed it was attached to his body. His ears went pink, that thing they did when Mom caught him eating ice cream straight from the carton. He set the creamer back on the table, way too carefully, like it might explode.

"Reflexes," he said. The grin he flashed her was all wrong. Too quick, too bright. "Must be all those video games I played in college."

Sophia's brain was still trying to catch up. Her dad was the guy who tripped over the garden hose. Who walked into door frames when he was

thinking too hard. Who wore Hawaiian shirts every single day like some kind of personal brand commitment. Who definitely, *definitely* should not have been able to do... whatever that was.

"Right," she said. "You should go pro."

"Eat your toast," Mom said from the stove, completely oblivious, waving her spatula like a conductor's baton. "And don't encourage him. If he thinks he has reflexes, he'll try to fix the roof again."

Dad went back to his tablet, but his hand shook a little when he picked up his coffee.

Sophia chewed her toast. It tasted like cardboard. She wanted to ask: *what was that, how did you do that, why are you pretending it was normal.* But the words stuck in her throat. Instead, she stared at the creamer, sitting there innocent and cow-shaped, like it hadn't just broken the laws of physics.

"We're heading out right after we drop you off," Mom said, sliding eggs onto Sophia's plate. The kitchen smelled like butter and coffee grounds, Dad always burned the coffee on the warmer while he read. The morning light coming through the window caught Mom's collection of geodes on the sill, turning the gray Seattle drizzle into something almost pretty. "Should be back around dinner. Six, maybe seven depending on traffic."

"I know."

"There's leftover pasta in the fridge if we're running late. And Mrs. Halvorsen next door knows you'll be home alone for a few hours—"

"I'm fourteen, not four."

Mom grinned and kissed the top of her head. Her shampoo smelled like coconut. "Text me after soccer practice."

Sophia rolled her eyes, but she texted anyway, later that afternoon, still high off the adrenaline of two perfect goals. "Scored twice. Coach says I might start next game."

The response came fast. Heart emojis and a photo from somewhere high on a trail, mountain peaks stacked up behind Mom's grinning face

like rows of gray teeth. "*Beautiful up here. Dad says hi. Almost to the summit, home soon. Love you, Soph.*"

Sophia was heating up the pasta when the doorbell rang.

She knew something was wrong before she even opened the door. Nobody rang the doorbell at seven-thirty on a Tuesday unless something was wrong.

Through the peephole she saw the dark blue uniform, the serious face, the way the police officer's hand was already reaching for her radio like she might need backup just to say what she'd come to say.

The words came in pieces. Rockslide. Recovery efforts. I'm so sorry.

The words washed over her, but her brain was stuck on the creamer, falling and falling and falling, caught by a hand that moved too fast to see.

She should have asked. She should have *asked.*

Five days later, she stood at their graves.

❧

The roses smelled wrong.

That was the thing Sophia couldn't stop thinking about as she stood beside her parents' graves. Roses were supposed to smell sweet, like summer, like her mother's garden back home in Seattle. These roses smelled like a refrigerator. Like something preserved when it should have been alive.

She adjusted the collar of the black dress Aunt Patricia had forced her into this morning. The fabric was stiff and scratchy against her neck, and the hem hung past her knees in a way that made her feel like she was wear ing a costume. This wasn't her. None of this was her.

"Such a lovely service," someone whispered behind her. Sophia didn't turn around.

"She's holding up so well," another voice added. "Poor thing."

Sophia's hands clenched at her sides. She wasn't holding up. She was standing still because she didn't know what else to do. She was breathing

because her body kept doing it without asking permission. None of that was the same as holding up.

The minister was saying something about eternal rest, about peace, about God's mysterious plan. Sophia wanted to scream at him that there was no plan, mysterious or otherwise, that could justify taking both her parents at once and leaving her completely alone.

But she didn't scream. She stood there in her ridiculous dress with refrigerator roses filling her nose and tried to remember the last thing her mother had said to her.

Text me after soccer practice.

Five ordinary words. Mothers said things like that every day without thinking, because they'd always be around to say them again.

A hand landed on her shoulder, Aunt Patricia, with her perfectly manicured nails and her cloud of expensive perfume. "The reception is at the hotel, sweetheart. Your grandfather is very anxious to see you."

Grandfather. She'd met Richard Lumeth exactly twice in her fourteen years: once at a Christmas gathering when she was too young to remember anything except that he smelled like pine trees, and once at her grandmother's funeral when she was eight. He'd seemed nice enough in a distracted, awkward sort of way. Her mother had always seemed uncomfortable around him, though she'd never explained why.

Now Sophia was going to live with him. In Elwha, Washington, a town she'd never been to, couldn't even picture. Her social worker had explained it very gently, like she was delivering news about a sick pet rather than the total destruction of Sophia's life. Her parents hadn't left a will. There was no other family willing to take her. Richard was her only option.

"Maybe now she'll soften up a little," Aunt Patricia said quietly to Uncle Frank as they walked toward the parking lot. She clearly thought Sophia couldn't hear. "Without Marsha encouraging that tomboy phase, perhaps—"

"Pat," Uncle Frank warned.

Sophia stopped walking. Her aunt and uncle continued for several steps before noticing.

"Sophia? The car's this way, dear."

"My mother," Sophia said, her voice flat, "never encouraged anything. She just let me be myself. There's a difference."

Aunt Patricia's smile went rigid. "Of course, sweetheart. I didn't mean—"

"I know what you meant."

She turned away before her aunt could respond, walking in the direc tion she thought the car might be. It didn't matter if she got lost. Nothing really mattered anymore.

In her pocket, her fingers found the small wooden music box her mother had pressed into her hands the week before the accident. "Hold onto this for me, Soph. I've been meaning to put it somewhere safe."

Sophia hadn't asked why. She'd been half-asleep, annoyed about being woken early, eager to get back to her dreams. Now the music box was the only thing she had that still smelled like home, like her mother's perfume, like that unexplainable scent that had always meant safety and love and everything that was now gone forever.

She clutched it through the fabric of her dress and didn't let go.

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The reception passed in a blur of casseroles and handshakes and people telling Sophia how sorry they were, how much they'd loved her parents, how she should call if she ever needed anything. She kept her expression neutral and said thank you and didn't believe a word of it.

Her grandfather arrived late. Tall and thin. White hair that looked like it had been combed maybe once this week and immediately forgotten. His suit was clearly old. The lapels were too wide, the shoulders too boxy. But it was clean and pressed. He moved slowly, his weathered face creased with grief, real grief, not the polite version everyone else had been wearing.

"Sophia." He stopped in front of her, seeming uncertain what to do with his hands. "I'm so sorry about your mother. And your father. Jerry was a good man."

"Thank you." The words came automatically, the same ones she'd said to everyone.

Richard nodded, equally awkward. "The drive to Elwha is about four hours. We can leave whenever you're ready."

"I'm ready now."

Surprise flickered across his face, he'd probably expected her to want to stay longer, to savor these last moments in Seattle, to say proper goodbyes. But there was nothing left to say goodbye to. Her home had already been packed up, her belongings reduced to a few boxes that would be shipped later. Her friends had cried at the funeral, but she knew she'd probably never see them again. What was the point of dragging it out?

"All right then." Richard patted his pockets like he was checking for something. "The truck's out front."

She followed him out of the hotel, ignoring Aunt Patricia's protests about not having had dessert yet. The late summer air was warm against her face, carrying the salt smell of Puget Sound and the distant rumble of traffic.

Richard's truck was old but well-maintained, its green paint faded to the color of sage. The interior smelled like coffee and old books and some thing else, pine, she realized. Just like she remembered from when she was little.

They drove in silence for the first hour. Seattle shrank in the side mir ror, skyscrapers dissolving into suburbs, suburbs into forest. The trees got bigger and darker as they headed west, ancient firs and cedars that seemed to swallow the afternoon light.

"Your mother used to love this drive," Richard said. His voice was rough, like he hadn't used it in a while. "When she was your age, we'd come out here on weekends. She'd spend hours in those woods. I couldn't keep her out of them."

Sophia didn't know what to say. Her mother as a teenager, wandering through forests? The image refused to form. The practical, organized woman who'd raised her had erased every trace of this wild girl. It was like hearing about a stranger.

"There's a lot about her you don't know," Richard continued, almost to himself. "A lot I never understood, either."

"Like what?"

He was quiet for a long moment. When he spoke again, his voice had changed, careful now, guarded. "Like why she stopped coming back. Why she never brought you to visit. Why she—" He stopped himself, shook his head. "Never mind. Old history now, I suppose."

The silence settled back over them, thicker now. Sophia turned to stare out the window again, watching the endless green blur past. Her mother had kept secrets, apparently. Everyone had secrets.

She slipped her hand into her pocket and touched the music box again. Its familiar shape was a comfort, a tiny anchor to the life she'd lost. She wound the small key on its underside and let it play a few notes, some thing classical, something her mother had hummed sometimes when she didn't know Sophia was listening.

The notes faded into the quiet of the truck, absorbed by the sound of tires on wet pavement and the whisper of rain beginning to fall.

Somewhere ahead, Elwha waited. Her new home. Her new life.

Sophia closed her eyes and tried not to think about how completely alone she felt.

CHAPTER TWO

The Bigfoot House

Elwha announced itself with a sign.

And what a sign: a massive wooden billboard featuring a grinning cartoon Sasquatch waving at passing cars. "WELCOME TO ELWHA," it proclaimed in letters carved three feet tall. "BIGFOOT CAPITAL OF WASHINGTON."

Sophia stared at it as they drove past, certain she must be seeing things. The late afternoon light caught the billboard's weathered surface, highlighting the chips and cracks of years spent in the Pacific Northwest rain. Beyond it, the town emerged from the forest like something that had grown rather than been built, cedar-shingled roofs dark with moss, storefronts painted in colors faded by decades of drizzle.

"They're very proud of the Sasquatch heritage around here," Richard said, and she couldn't tell if he was joking.

Main Street answered her question: he wasn't. The coffee shop was called the "Bigfoot Brew," its windows steamy against the chill, the smell of roasted beans drifting out whenever someone opened the door. The diner across from it advertised "Sasquatch-Sized Portions", a hand-painted menu in the window promised burgers named after famous sight ings. Even the gas station had a ten-foot wooden Bigfoot statue standing guard outside, one frozen hand raised in an eternal greeting to customers,

its paint peeling in the salted air that drifted up from the Strait of Juan de Fuca.

"You've got to be kidding me," Sophia muttered.

Richard parked in front of a hardware store, the only business on the block without a sasquatch reference, and turned off the engine. The truck ticked as it cooled. Outside, a light rain had begun to fall, more mist than drops, softening everything it touched.

"Welcome to Elwha. Population about three thousand, depending on whether you count the seasonal research teams."

"Research teams?"

"Cryptozoologists, mostly. Amateur Bigfoot hunters. They set up camp in the national forest every summer." He scratched his chin, looking a bit embarrassed. "I may have helped get some of them started."

Sophia remembered, distantly, her mother mentioning something about Richard being "eccentric." At the time, she'd assumed that meant he collected stamps or built model trains. Not that he lived in a town that had apparently turned Bigfoot into its entire cultural identity.

"Let's get you home," Richard said. "Mrs. Parsons has been keeping an eye on things while I was in Seattle. She probably has dinner ready."

Home turned out to be a Victorian house on the edge of town, where the pavement gave way to gravel and the backyards melted into ancient forest. It was beautiful in a creaky, neglected sort of way, three stories of faded blue paint and wraparound porches and windows that seemed to watch the road with patient expectation.

Inside, the Bigfoot theme continued. Maps covered nearly every wall, marked with pushpins and strings connecting sighting locations. Corkboards displayed blurry photographs of dark shapes between trees. Bookshelves overflowed with titles like "In Search of Sasquatch" and "The Legend of the Forest Giants" and "Bigfoot: America's Hidden Primate."

Sophia stood in the living room, slowly turning in a circle, trying to process what she was seeing.

"I know it's a lot," Richard said from behind her. "Your grandmother used to say the same thing. But fifty years of research adds up."

"Fifty years?"

He nodded, moving past her to straighten a stack of papers on the coffee table. "I saw something in those woods, back in 1976. Something that wasn't supposed to exist. The memory is strange, fragments, mostly. A massive shape between the trees. Eyes that seemed too intelligent. A sound I can't quite remember but still hear in my dreams sometimes." He paused, looking at her with an expression she couldn't read. "The details slip away when I try to focus on them, like trying to hold water in my hands. But I know what I saw was real. Spent my whole life trying to find it again. Trying to prove I wasn't crazy."

Before Sophia could respond, a door opened somewhere in the back of the house. A round, cheerful woman emerged, wiping her hands on a flour-dusted apron. "You must be Sophia! I've heard so much about you. I'm Mrs. Parsons, I live just down the road. Helped your grandfather get the house ready for you."

She pulled Sophia into a hug that smelled like cinnamon and laundry detergent. Sophia stood stiffly, enduring it, until Mrs. Parsons finally let go.

"I made pot roast for dinner. Richard said you might be hungry after the long drive."

"I don't—" Sophia started, but Richard was already leading the way to the kitchen, and Mrs. Parsons was steering her firmly in that direction, and somehow she ended up seated at a long wooden table with a plate of food she didn't remember asking for.

The pot roast was fine. The conversation was worse.

"Richard tells me you play soccer," Mrs. Parsons said, beaming. "We have a team at the middle school. I'm sure they'd love to have you."

"Maybe," Sophia said.

"And your hair is so practical! Very easy to maintain, I imagine."

Sophia touched her short-cropped hair. She'd cut it herself last year, chopping off the long brown waves her mother had always loved. A statement. A rejection of everything everyone expected her to be. Now it just marked her as different.

"You know," Mrs. Parsons continued, undeterred, "there's a lovely salon in town. Marcy could probably do something really cute with what you've got. Maybe add some layers, some volume—"

"I like my hair how it is."

The silence that followed was uncomfortable. Richard cleared his throat and asked Mrs. Parsons about her garden, and the conversation moved on, but the judgment radiated across the table anyway. Too short. Too boyish. Not pretty enough, not feminine enough, not trying hard enough.

She pushed food around her plate and waited for dinner to be over.

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Her bedroom was on the third floor, tucked under the eaves where the roof slanted at dramatic angles. Mrs. Parsons had clearly been in charge of decorating. Pale pink walls. A bedspread drowning in ruffles and flowers. A white vanity table with a lighted mirror sat in one corner, equipped with brushes and combs and a jewelry box that played music when you opened it.

It looked like a room designed for a completely different girl.

Sophia dropped her backpack on the bed. She placed a small suitcase next to the dresser, her only luggage, containing everything she'd been allowed to bring from Seattle, and walked to the window. The view was of trees. Endless trees, stretching back into darkness, their tops swaying gently in the evening wind.

Somewhere out there, if her grandfather was to be believed, Bigfoot was lurking. The thought should have been ridiculous. But standing in this strange room in this strange town, looking out at a forest older than human memory, it almost seemed possible.

Her phone buzzed: a text from Maya, her best friend back in Seattle.

how is it? are you ok??

Sophia stared at the message for a long time. She typed several responses and deleted them all. Finally, she just sent: *weird. ttyl.*

She put the phone face-down on the vanity and started unpacking. Her clothes went in the pink dresser. Her books, the few she'd been able to bring, filled one shelf of the bookcase. Her soccer cleats, muddy and worn, looked completely out of place next to the porcelain figurines Mrs. Parsons had arranged on the windowsill.

At the bottom of her backpack, she found the music box.

Sophia sat on the edge of the bed, the frilly, ridiculous bed, and held it in her hands. It was old, she knew. Her mother had owned it forever, kept it on her nightstand for as long as Sophia could remember. The wood was dark and worn smooth by years of handling. The brass fittings were tarnished but clean. A forest scene was painted on the lid, intricate and beautiful.

She wound the key and let it play.

The melody filled the room, soft, delicate, achingly familiar. Sophia closed her eyes. For one impossible moment, her mother's perfume surrounded her. Warm hands smoothed back her hair. A voice whispered goodnight, sweet dreams, I love you more than anything in the world.

The music box wound down. The silence rushed back in. Sophia sat alone in a pink room in a strange house in a town full of Bigfoot believers. She had never felt more completely, utterly lost.

She put the music box on the nightstand, lay down on top of the covers, and stared at the ceiling until the light faded from the window and darkness filled the room.

Tomorrow would be her first day at Elwha Middle School.

She couldn't bring herself to care.

CHAPTER THREE

The New Girl

The bus smelled like stale Cheetos and despair.

Sophia wedged herself into a seat near the back and pulled out her phone, hoping to project an aura of "leave me alone" strong enough to repel anyone who might want to make conversation. It mostly worked. A few kids glanced her way with open curiosity, new faces were clearly rare in Elwha, but nobody approached.

Elwha Middle School turned out to be a two-story brick building that looked like it had been constructed sometime around the invention of electricity and barely updated since. The front steps were worn into shallow dips from decades of students' feet. The American flag on the pole out front flapped in a cold wind that smelled like approaching rain.

The school felt like a downgrade. In Seattle, ninth graders attended the high school. In Elwha, the high school was only big enough for three grades, so ninth was still middle school. Inside, the halls were narrower than her school in Seattle, the lockers smaller, the ceilings lower. Everything felt compressed. Sophia found the main office and collected her schedule from a secretary who looked at her with slightly too much sympathy.

"You're the Sprite girl, aren't you? The one who lost her folks."

"Yes." Sophia took the paper from the woman's hand and turned away before she could say anything else.

First period was English, taught by a man named Mr. Howell who spoke too quietly and kept losing his place in his own lesson plan. Sophia found a seat in the back corner and spent the hour watching rain streak down the windows. Second period was math, which was at least impersonal, numbers didn't care who you were or what you'd lost. By third period, she was starting to feel the weight of being constantly observed. Every hallway, every classroom, eyes tracked her movements like she was an exotic animal at the zoo.

Science class was in Room 204, taught by Ms. Lisonbee, a young woman with wild curly hair, and an enthusiasm for chemistry that bordered on frightening. "Pair up for the lab project!" she called out as students filtered in. "I want proposals on my desk by Friday!"

The classroom did what it always did: longtime friends gravitated toward each other, established pairs claimed their tables, and Sophia found herself standing alone near the door, watching everyone else connect with practiced ease.

"You look like you need a partner."

The voice came from her left. Sophia turned to find a girl about her age with long dark hair pulled back in a simple ponytail and keen brown eyes that seemed to notice everything at once. She was wearing jeans and a plain gray sweater, nothing flashy, nothing designed to draw attention, but she carried herself with a quiet confidence that demanded notice anyway.

"I'm Olivia," the girl said. "Olivia Garcia."

"Sophia."

"I know." Olivia gave a small smile that seemed almost apologetic. "New kids are big news around here. Plus, the whole—" She stopped herself, looking uncomfortable. "Anyway. Partners?"

"Sure."

They claimed a table near the window. Olivia pulled out a notebook that was already half-filled with neat, organized notes, and started sketching ideas for their project. "Crystallization. Sugar or salt. Straightforward methodology, reliable results, good visual data."

"Okay."

Olivia glanced at her. "You're not much of a talker, are you?"

"Not lately."

"That's fine. I've been told I talk enough for two people anyway." She returned to her notebook, making a list of materials they'd need. "My dad works at the old copper mine, so I could probably get us some interesting mineral samples if we want to go that route instead. The mine's been closed for years, but they still maintain the research equipment."

"There's a research mine in this town?"

"The Jameson Mine. It's mostly geological surveys now, but my dad's part of a team studying—" She caught herself, looked embarrassed. "Sorry. I tend to ramble about random stuff. My mom says it's because I read too much. She'd rather I spent more time learning her recipes than buried in books."

"I don't mind." Sophia surprised herself by meaning it. There was something calming about Olivia's methodical way of thinking, her obvious intelligence. She reminded Sophia of girls she'd known back in Seattle, the ones who were too smart for their own good, who spent lunch periods in the library instead of the cafeteria because books were more reliable than people.

The period passed quickly. By the time the bell rang, they'd outlined their project (crystallization of various minerals, borrowing samples from Olivia's dad) and exchanged phone numbers. It was Sophia's most normal interaction since the funeral.

"Sit with me at lunch," Olivia said as they packed up. "If you want, I mean. No pressure."

"Okay."

The cafeteria was like every cafeteria in every middle school in America: too loud, too crowded, with invisible social barriers that everyone understood but nobody talked about. The popular kids held court near the windows. The athletes claimed the center tables. The various subgroups (the theater kids, the gamers, the art crowd) had their established territories around the edges.

Olivia led her to a table near the emergency exit, half-hidden behind a support pillar. "Best seat in the house," she said. "Nobody bothers us here."

"Us?"

Before Olivia could answer, a lunch tray crashed down onto the table across from them. Sophia flinched backward, hand instinctively coming up to protect her face, before she realized it wasn't an attack, just an arrival.

"The new girl!" The boy attached to the tray was grinning widely, his dark skin and open, friendly face making his excitement seem genuine rather than threatening. He was tall and stout, built like someone who did regular physical work. "Excellent. I was hoping I'd get a chance to meet you before Grace and her minions sank their claws in."

"Sophia, this is Lucas Fox," Olivia said, in the tone of someone who'd given up trying to control a natural disaster. "Lucas, don't scare her off."

"Me? Scare her? I'm a delight." Lucas dropped into his seat and immediately started shoveling cafeteria spaghetti into his mouth. Between bites, he continued: "So you're Lumeth's granddaughter, right? The Bigfoot guy?"

Sophia stiffened. "He's, yeah. I'm living with him."

"Cool. My family's been tracking Sasquatch sightings for three generations. My grandpa was one of the original witnesses, back in the seventies. Him and your grandfather used to hunt together, actually. Before they had their falling-out."

"Falling-out?"

Lucas waved a fork vaguely. "Old drama. Something about methodology, I think. My grandpa thought Lumeth was too scientific. Wanted more boots-on-the-ground tracking, less fancy equipment. They haven't spoken in like thirty years."

"Lucas," Olivia warned.

"What? She should know! If she's going to live here, she needs to understand the Bigfoot politics. It's a whole thing." He leaned toward Sophia conspiratorially. "There are factions. Camps. Annual conventions

with PowerPoint presentations about footprint casting techniques. It's intense."

Sophia looked between them, trying to figure out if this was an elabo rate joke. "You're serious."

"Deadly serious. Elwha was founded by Sasquatch enthusiasts, did you know that? Back in the 1920s. The original settlers came out here specifically to look for Bigfoot. Most of the families in town trace their interest back generations."

"Including yours?"

Lucas shrugged. "My parents think it's all nonsense now. Sold out to mainstream skepticism. But Grandpa keeps the faith." He grinned again, something slightly manic in his eyes. "And so do I."

"Lucas is convinced he's going to find Bigfoot before we graduate." Olivia rolled her eyes.

"Determined," Lucas said. "Convinced is for amateurs." He pointed his fork at Sophia. "You'll see. Living with Lumeth, you'll get it. The guy may be ancient, but he's got the best evidence collection on the Olympic Peninsula. Maybe in the whole country."

Sophia didn't know what to say to any of this. A week ago, she'd been worried about making the varsity soccer team and whether her lab partner had finished their share of the biology project. Now she was eating cafeteria spaghetti with two strangers in a town that had organized its entire identity around a creature that didn't exist.

"I think I need to just survive my first day," she said. "The Bigfoot stuff can wait."

Lucas looked briefly disappointed, but nodded. "Fair. Small doses. I get it."

The rest of lunch passed in surprisingly easy conversation. Lucas filled her in on everything: the school, the teachers worth avoiding, and the unwritten social rules of a small town. Olivia tossed in the occasional sarcastic comment. For the first time since arriving in Elwha, Sophia gave herself permission to relax.

It was too soon to call it friendship. But it was something.

They were gathering their trays to leave when a voice cut through the cafeteria noise.

"Well, well. The new girl."

Sophia turned. A girl was approaching their table, blonde, beautiful in that calculated way that suggested hours of practice in front of mirrors, flanked by a brown-haired girl who looked like a slightly less polished copy. Their outfits were casual but expensive. Their smiles were sharp.

"I'm Grace Wilson." The blonde stopped a few feet away, looking Sophia up and down with obvious assessment. "I just wanted to welcome you to Elwha."

"Thanks." Sophia kept her voice neutral.

"That's quite a look you've got going." Grace's gaze lingered on Sophia's hair, her plain t-shirt, her worn sneakers. "Very... interesting fashion choices."

The brown-haired girl (Suzette, Sophia would learn later) giggled on cue.

"I like to be comfortable," Sophia said.

"Obviously." Grace's smile didn't waver. "Well. We'll be seeing you around, I'm sure. Elwha's pretty small. Hard to avoid anyone." She turned and walked away, Suzette trailing behind like a well-trained shadow.

"Don't let her get to you." Olivia kept her voice low. "Grace likes to stake out new territory. You'll be old news by next week."

"That was actually mild," Lucas added. "She must be having a good day."

Grace disappeared into the crowd. Something cold settled in Sophia's stomach. She'd dealt with mean girls before. Usually she could handle them, keep her head down, stay out of their way, wait for them to find a new target.

But something about the way Grace had looked at her suggested this wasn't going to be that simple.

She gathered her tray and followed Olivia toward the exit, trying to shake off the feeling that her already-difficult new life had just become more complicated.